Jonah’s unfinished conversation

Read Jonah 3:9–4:11. Sort six claims by what the passage supports, conflicts with or leaves open. Bring a Bible in the translation your group uses.

SUPPORTS
The text backs this claim.

CONFLICTS
The text gives a reason to reject it.

LEAVES OPEN
The passage does not settle it.

Cut the cards apart, or write a category beside each. Add the verse you used.

A

Jonah names God's mercy while explaining his earlier flight.

Category _____
Verse _____

B

The king says he knows for certain what God will do.

Category _____
Verse _____

C

Jonah is pleased about the plant that provides shade.

Category _____
Verse _____

D

Jonah grew the plant himself.

Category _____
Verse _____

E

The final question refers to animals as well as people.

Category _____
Verse _____

F

The chapter reports that Jonah changes his mind after the final question.

Category _____
Verse _____

Facilitator steps, roles and answer key are on page 2.

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Keep the passage open

Suggested length: 20 minutes. Adjust the pace to your group. The activity is a close-reading exercise for adults or teens.

Prepare · about 2 minutes

Bring a Bible for each pair. Choose a reader, finder and questioner. In a pair, share the third role. Scissors are optional. Keep the answer key face down.

Read · about 4 minutes

Read Jonah 3:9–4:11 together. Notice the change from the city’s response to Jonah’s response. Revisit the wider book if a question needs context.

Sort · about 8 minutes

Place each card under Supports, Conflicts or Leaves open. Record a verse and explain the decision. Rotate the roles after two cards. Disagreements are a reason to reread.

Check and discuss · about 6 minutes

Compare the six decisions with the key. Revise a decision when the passage gives a reason. End by discussing the question below.

THREE ROLES TO ROTATE

Reader — Read Jonah 3:9–4:11 aloud from your chosen Bible. Reread a requested verse and its surrounding sentence.

Finder — Find the strongest verse for a card. Read enough context for the others to check the connection.

Questioner — Ask what words support the decision. If a claim goes beyond the passage, ask what information is missing.

ANSWER KEY

A · Supports · Jonah 4:2 — Jonah connects his earlier flight with what he knows about God's character.

B · Conflicts · Jonah 3:9 — The king asks whether God may turn and relent. His question expresses uncertainty.

C · Supports · Jonah 4:6 — The narrative reports Jonah's gladness because of the plant.

D · Conflicts · Jonah 4:10 — God says Jonah did not work for the plant or make it grow.

E · Supports · Jonah 4:11 — The question names the people of Nineveh and its many animals.

F · Leaves open · Jonah 4:11 / end of the book — The book ends with the question. It does not report a reply or a later change of mind.

A QUESTION TO LEAVE WITH

How does the final question change the way you read the earlier scene with the plant? Point to details in Jonah 4:6–11. Keep personal reflection separate from claims about what Jonah did next.

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